



the Shield,” Habas had told his players, after taking over from his compatriot Juan Ferrando mid-season at Mohun Bagan SG, as revealed by the team’s assistant coach, Manuel Perez.

Mohun Bagan seemed to be falling out of the league winner’s

Into the big league: Mohun Bagan beat Mumbai City FC 2-1 to win the League Shield. PTI

race after suffering three consecutive losses forcing the departure of Ferrando before Habas arrived to steady the team and record nine wins, two draws and a solitary loss in 12 matches to secure the League Shield and sent the Mohun Bagan fans in a mad celebration over the team’s new silverware.

Amitabha Das Sharma

One for the fans

Chennaiyin FC, the joint-second-most successful club in the Indian Super League (ISL), with two titles, has struggled in the bottom rungs of the standings in the last few years.

It changed three head coaches — Csaba László, Bozidar Bandovic and then the interim coach Sabir Pasha — but neither could steer it to the playoffs.

With debilitating performances, the turnout at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium in Chennai, the club’s home ground, shrunk.

But all of it changed this season. Owen Coyle, the Scotsman who had previously taken the Marina Machans to the final, took charge of the club, taking it back into the

knockouts after four years.

The JLN Stadium had fans back in the stands again, about 7000 in its last home game against NorthEast United FC.

Before kick-off, two tifos were unfurled by the home fans — one read ‘Chennaiyin till I die’, while the other said ‘Rise as one’ as David Sting, one of the most loyal fans of the club roared with thousands of fans, despite the humidity at the Marina Arena.

The players delivered too. From trailing 0-1, Chennaiyin FC registered a comeback win, with Aakash Sangwan equalising with an Olympic goal and Ankit Mukherjee winning it with a stoppage-time strike.

Though its qualification was sealed the next day — after East Bengal lost 1-4 to Punjab — it felt like Christmas for the players outside the stadium.

Fans clicked pictures with the coach, Jordan Murray signed jerseys and local boy Alexander Romario Jesuraj danced to local songs.

Though the club’s run ended with a 1-2 loss to Odisha in the playoffs, CFC will find solace in getting back to familiar territory — luring the fans into the stadium with the most important aspect of the sport — hope, to play, to improve and someday, win.

Neeladri Bhattacharjee



Heartwarming: Chennaiyin FC’s players and head coach thank the fans for turning up at the stadium after their last home game, which they won 2-1. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT